

on Wall Street that “professional investing” is an oxymoron on a par with “military intelligence.” So where does that leave the pro as well as the amateur? In need of recruiting a panel of the greatest stock-pickers and market gurus, past and present, to instruct on the art of investing. Where can we find such a panel? Here in *The Book of Investing Wisdom*.

Wall Street. From its historical beginnings, it has been an epicenter for epic battles, financial and otherwise. One large step backward in time is necessary to give full meaning to Wall Street. Its roots lay in 1624, when the Dutch founded and settled New Amsterdam on the southern tip of Manhattan, reportedly buying it from the native Americans for about \$24 worth of trinkets (a deal Donald Trump, who concludes this collection, must certainly admire). Unfortunately for the Dutch, the British also had their eyes on this upscale piece of property, and the residents of New Amsterdam were forced to build a 12-foot-high wooden stockade to protect themselves from repeated attacks. Not to be stymied, in 1664 the British simply sailed their cannon-laden warships into the harbor, and the Dutch surrendered. In 1685, the British built a road along the line of the stockade, which had been torn down, and named it Wall Street. Little did they know that on this same spot the financing would be raised to pay for the war that would expel them from the United States.

While the French had been trading paper since the twelfth century and the English had established securities markets by 1720, the United States did not witness any securities trading until the Revolutionary War, when a smattering of bonds were issued to raise fighting money. However, the first major issue of U.S. securities did not come until 1790, when the Federal Government issued \$80 million in bonds to refinance all war debt. And so, the national debt was birthed. At that time New York City was the nation’s capital, so it immediately took center stage in American finance, and public securities auctions were held there twice daily in 1791 and 1792. The first step toward a more formal stock exchange came in 1792, when 24 prominent brokers